The Little Girl

The big idea

In **Katherine Mansfield's** story, a little girl named **Kezia** is terrified of her stern father. One frightening night shows her that behind his strict exterior he has a loving heart. The story is about a **father–daughter relationship**, misunderstanding, and how children need affection as well as discipline.

Summary

1. Kezia is afraid of her father. In the morning he comes to say goodbye before work; in the evening the house relaxes only after he has had his tea. When she talks to him she **stammers**, and he scolds her for it.
2. Her **grandmother** suggests she make a **pincushion** for his birthday. Looking for stuffing, Kezia tears up some papers from his bedside table, not knowing they are his **great speech for the Port Authority**.
3. Father is furious. He **beats her palms with a ruler**. Kezia sobs and asks her grandmother why God made fathers.
4. Next door, **Mr Macdonald** plays happily with his five children. Kezia sees that not all fathers are alike.
5. One night her mother is in **hospital** and Grandmother is away. Kezia has a **nightmare** about a butcher with a knife and rope. Her father comes, carries her to his bed and comforts her.
6. As she lies on his arm, she realises he is tired from working hard for the family. She thinks, "Poor father! Not so big, after all", and asks him to keep his heart warm for her.

Characters

- **Kezia**: sensitive, timid, observant; her fear turns to understanding and love.
- **Father**: strict and hot-tempered on the surface, but caring; he works hard and has little time for play.
- **Grandmother**: affectionate and gentle; Kezia's refuge.
- **Mr Macdonald**: a contrast, a playful, cheerful father.

Themes

- **Communication gap** between parents and children.
- **Appearances can deceive**: the father's harshness hid love.
- **Discipline versus affection**: children need both.
- **Growing up**: Kezia matures by seeing the world from her father's side.

TURNING POINT

The nightmare scene is the turning point. Fear changes to sympathy when Kezia sees her father as a tired, ordinary man who loves her.

THE FATHER WAS NOT CRUEL

Many students write that he hated Kezia. He was strict and short-tempered, but the ending clearly shows his love.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why was Kezia afraid of her father? What made her change her opinion? Compare Kezia's father and Mr Macdonald. How should parents treat children? Value points: stammering, ruler punishment, pincushion, nightmare, "not so big after all".

Quick recap

- Kezia fears her strict father and stammers before him.

- Pincushion stuffed with his speech leads to punishment.
- Nightmare shows his tender side; she understands and loves him.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "The Little Girl"?

   (a) Ruskin Bond (b) Anton Chekhov (c) Katherine Mansfield (d) O. Henry

2. Why did Kezia stammer in front of her father?

   (a) She was frightened of him (b) She had a speech disorder from birth (c) She was pretending (d) Her grandmother told her to

3. What did Kezia use to stuff the pincushion?

   (a) Cotton from her pillow (b) Old newspapers (c) Her mother's letters (d) Her father's important speech papers

4. How was Kezia punished?

   (a) She was locked in her room (b) She was sent to bed without dinner (c) Her palms were struck with a ruler (d) She was not allowed to play

5. Mr Macdonald is presented as

   (a) a strict neighbour (b) a cheerful, playful father (c) Kezia's uncle (d) a doctor

6. What finally changed Kezia's feelings for her father?

   (a) He bought her a gift (b) Her grandmother explained his behaviour (c) He comforted her after a nightmare (d) He apologised for punishing her

7. Why was Kezia afraid of her father? How did her opinion change?

8. What does the story teach about the relationship between parents and children?

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. c 5. b 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes